

A Walk Along the Charles

Berklee → Harvard Bridge → Memorial Drive → Longfellow → Esplanade · about 4.6 miles, roughly 95 minutes

One of Prof. Gibson's favorite summer walks in Boston. The loop crosses the river twice, gives you views of both skylines, and ends back at the Esplanade — most students never realize how much park is sitting half a block from class.

The Route

Leave Berklee at 150 Massachusetts Avenue and walk north on Mass Ave over the Harvard Bridge (locally the Mass Ave Bridge, famously measured in Smoots) into Cambridge. Turn right onto Memorial Drive right at the foot of the bridge and stay on the riverside sidewalk the entire way east — past the MIT boathouses and the open lawns. As you near the Longfellow, cross Memorial Drive at the signalized crosswalk and step onto the bridge walkway on Main Street. The skyline view as you cross back into Boston is the best in the city. Drop onto the Esplanade at Charles Circle and follow the riverside path west all the way home.



Map: Google Maps · walking route hand-traced by Prof. Gibson.

One thing to know before you go. Storrow Drive runs between the city and the park along the entire Boston bank. It looks like a regular avenue but functions like a small highway — fast cars, no shoulders, almost no pedestrian feeling. Cross only at the signalized intersections or the dedicated footbridges (Fiedler is the most central). Plan your entry and exit points before you set out.

Prof. Kramer Gibson · Berklee College of Music

What You Are Walking Through

A short field guide to the basin

A Park Built on Top of a River

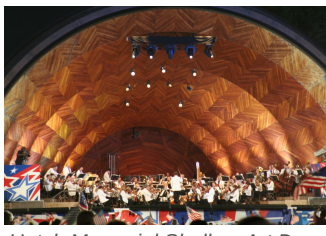
The Charles you see today is not the Charles that was here two centuries ago. Until 1910 the river was tidal — a wide stretch of mudflats that drained twice a day. The Charles River Dam, built that year just east of the Longfellow, held the water at a constant level and turned the basin into the calm sheet you see now. Frederick Law Olmsted had already designed the first riverside park here in 1892, called Charlesbank, which included the country's first free public outdoor gym. Helen Osborne Storrow funded the major 1930s expansion in memory of her husband James — whose name is now stuck, unfortunately, on the highway running between the park and the city.



Harvard / Mass Ave Bridge — the Smoot bridge



Longfellow Bridge — Red Line crossing back into Boston



Hatch Memorial Shell — Art Deco bandshell on the Esplanade



Charles River Esplanade — riverside parkland and bike paths

The Esplanade is bike country. The whole loop sits on the Dr. Paul Dudley White Bike Path, an 18-mile circuit that wraps the basin on both banks. Locals ride it for fitness, for commuting between Cambridge and Back Bay, and for the view. Walk to the right, listen for bells, and stop to look at the water — one of the most underused beautiful things in Boston.

Practical Notes

Memorial Drive closes to cars on summer Sundays, the best day for this walk. The Longfellow has a wide pedestrian walkway on both sides; pick the downstream side for the skyline view. Water fountains and bathrooms exist near the Hatch Shell. The route is flat the entire way. If you only have 45 minutes, cut the loop short by crossing back at the Mass Ave bridge instead of pushing east to the Longfellow.

Crossing Storrow Drive Safely

Storrow Drive is the only barrier between the park and the city. There are five safe pedestrian crossings between Boston University and the Public Garden. Use one; do not improvise.



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